imperial power. Practically, for most of the colonial period, the British were interested in only those aspects of their subjects that could be used as indicators of their loyalty or lack of it. In the case of Burma, religion was more important than ethnicity in this respect.

Tonkin also claims that the idea of Rohingya identity is purely a construct of post-1948 ethnic politics. The word 'Rohingya', he says, 'came into use after independence in 1948, notably in the wake of a "jihadist" uprising which plagued Arakan … until 1961 when Northern Arakan was designated the Mayu Frontier District and placed under military administration'. The Burmese government, he says, sometimes used the word thereafter, but this usage stopped after the 1962 coup.[75] The word 'jihadist' is often used by Burmese Buddhists to describe the brief revolt of 1947, and has connotations of Al-Qaeda-type terrorism. It is of course true that Mayu was administered by the military after 1948, but it was not the only frontier area of Burma to be administered this way after independence and in 1964 Mayu again became administratively part of Rakhine, thenceforth treated as a normal region of the country. Finally, as we have already shown, the advent of military rule in 1962 indeed saw a gradual increase in the persecution of the Rohingyas.

Other, less sophisticated, writers conflate the common argument that the increase in the Muslim population was purely the result of British policy with a claim that this was also designed to spread Wahhabist ideology:

> Most of the Bengali immigrants were influenced by the Farai-di movement in Bengal that propagated the ideology of the Wahhabis of Arabia, which advocated settling ikhwan or brethren in agricultural communities near to the places of water resources. The peasants, according to the teaching, besides cultivating the land should be ready for waging a holy war upon the call by their lords.[76]

The argument is that a substantial number of Muslims moved from Bengal to Arakan, when both were ruled by the British Empire, at the behest of Saudi Wahhabis.

The remainder of Tonkin's article, 'Rohingya' a Political, not Ethnic Label', is a detailed argument about which dialects were spoken where. He concludes it thus: 'The only reasonable conclusion is that "Rohingya" was never used historically as an ethnic designation'. Rather, he says, it was 'fashioned after the Second World War to define the majority of Muslims resident in the north of Rakhine State'. Therefore, 'it should not surprise us in the least that the Myanmar Government decline to accept "Rohingya" as